

EAT YOUR GREEN

SERIES

BOOK 2

RAISING KIDS *in a* JUNK FOOD WORLD

Raising Healthy Eaters in an
Ultra-Processed Food World.



PRERNA SULTANIA



Acknowledgements



This book may carry one author's name on the cover, but it was shaped by countless people and experiences along the way.



To every parent who has ever questioned whether they were doing enough, worried about a picky eater, negotiated one more bite, or searched for answers late at night—thank you. Your challenges, questions, and determination inspired this work.



To the researchers, health professionals, educators, and child development experts whose work continues to deepen our understanding of children's eating behaviours, thank you for making evidence accessible and practical.



To the families who remind us every day that healthy eating is about more than nutrition—it is about connection, culture, relationships, and love—thank you for being the reason this book exists.



And most importantly, to the children.

May you grow up curious, confident, and free from food guilt. May you learn to trust your bodies, enjoy your meals, and build a lifelong relationship with food that supports both health and happiness.



*“ Every healthy habit begins with a small moment,
repeated with love. ”*



With gratitude,

Prerna Sultania ♥



Creator of the **Eat Your Green Series**





COPYRIGHT

All rights reserved.

This book, including all content, concepts, text, images, worksheets, and design, is the intellectual property of **Prerna Sultania**.

No part of this book may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or any information storage and retrieval system, without prior written permission from the author.

This book is for personal use only. You may not resell, republish, or share it in any format.

Thank you for respecting the time, creativity, and heart that went into creating this resource for you and your family.

*Let's raise kind eaters and a healthier tomorrow,
together.*



© 2025 Prerna Sultania
All Rights Reserved.



Meet the *Author*



Prerna Sultania

Parent • Founder • Children's Food
Education Advocate



As a parent, I understand how confusing food and nutrition can feel in today's world.

Children are surrounded by marketing, ultra-processed foods, screens, and endless messages about what they should eat.

Like many parents, I found myself searching for practical, realistic ways to help children build healthier habits without pressure, guilt, or perfection.

That journey inspired the **Eat Your Green Series**—a collection of books designed to help families create positive food environments and raise confident eaters.

My goal is simple:

To help parents feel informed, empowered, and supported as they navigate the everyday challenges, of feeding children in a modern food environment.

“ Small changes
create lifelong habits. ”



Creator of the
EAT YOUR GREEN SERIES

*Helping families raise confident eaters,
one small step at a time.*



RAISING KIDS IN A JUNK FOOD WORLD





Introduction

A Note Before We Begin

Every parent wants their child to eat well.

Yet today's children are growing up in a world filled with food marketing, ultra-processed snacks, screens, and constant temptation.

If healthy eating feels harder than it should, you're not imagining it.

What This Book Will Help You Do



Understand why children crave junk food



Reduce mealtime battles



Build food curiosity



Navigate parties, grandparents, and fast food



Raise a child who trusts themselves around food

*“Healthy eating isn't about raising a perfect child.
It's about raising a confident one.”*

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Remember:



Progress beats perfection.



Small changes create lasting habits.



Connection matters more than control.



One step at a time is enough.



Welcome to the Journey

10 Chapters. One Goal.
Raising a child who trusts
themselves around food.

Table of Contents



UNDERSTANDING THE WORLD

- 1 The Junk Food World Is Real — And It's Not Your Fault
- 2 What Healthy Eating Actually Means for Kids



BUILDING THE FOUNDATION

- 3 The Home Food Environment
- 4 Handling Grandparents, Relatives & the Candy Aunt



NAVIGATING REAL LIFE

- 5 Birthday Parties, Functions & the Holiday Spiral
- 6 What To Do When Your Kid Only Wants Fast Food



SHAPING THE CONVERSATION

- 7 Talking To Kids About Food Without Creating Food Issues
- 8 Building Food Curiosity At Home
- 9 Screen Time & Food — The Hidden Connection



THE BIG PICTURE

- 10 The Long Game — Raising an Adult With a Healthy Relationship With Food



BONUS



Frequently Asked Questions

“Healthy eating isn't built through perfect meals.
It's built through thousands of small moments.”

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN



Understand why
children crave
junk food



Build a healthier
home food
environment



Handle parties,
grandparents, and
fast food with
confidence



Talk about food
without creating
pressure



Raise a child who
trusts themselves
around food



CHAPTER 1

The Junk Food World Is Real – And It's Not Your Fault



Understanding the world our kids live in is
the first step to raising healthy eaters.

You're not
failing.
You're parenting
in a world
designed to
make your job
harder. ♡

be
kind
to
yourself
♡



CHAPTER 1

SECTION 1

You're Not a Failing Parent – You're Up Against a Billion-Dollar Industry



It's been a long day. You're tired.
Your child is hungry.
Dinner didn't go as planned.

So you hand over the fries.
The nuggets. The juice box.

And almost immediately,
the guilt creeps in.

“

*“Why is this so hard?”
“Other parents probably
manage this better.”
“Am I ruining my child's
eating habits?”*

The truth is, you're not failing.
You're parenting in a world that's designed
to make your job harder.

DID YOU KNOW?



Food companies spend
\$2 billion+ per year
marketing directly to children.



By age 3, most kids can
recognize brand logos
before they can read.



Kids see thousands of
food and beverage ads
every single year.



THEN

vs.

NOW



Limited TV ads



Occasional treats



One cereal option



Outdoor boredom



Ads everywhere



Constant snack culture



Entire aisles
designed for kids



Screens + food
stimulation



Awareness changes the conversation from
“Why am I failing?”
to “What am I really up against?”
And that shift matters.



How Food Marketing Gets Inside Your Child's Brain

Children are not naturally drawn toward neon-colored cereal mascots or cartoon-shaped crackers by accident.

Food marketing aimed at children is highly intentional, carefully researched, and deeply psychological.

Companies know something incredibly important: **If they can win a child's loyalty early, they may keep that customer for years.**

From the moment they wake up to the time they go to bed, your child is surrounded by messages designed to make certain foods look fun, exciting, and irresistible.

“

If companies can win a child's loyalty early, they may keep that customer for years.

WHERE KIDS SEE FOOD MARKETING TODAY



YouTube & Videos

Food ads, unboxing videos, snack challenges, and influencer content.



Games & Apps

In-game ads, branded games, and in-app rewards.



Schools & Events

Sponsorships, promotions, and branded activities at school.



Influencers & Social Media

Kids see their favorite creators eating, reviewing, and promoting foods.



Stores & Packaging

Bright packaging, end-cap displays, toys, and eye-level shelf placement.



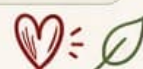
TV & Streaming Platforms

Ads during shows, cartoons, and even on “kid-friendly” platforms.



These messages are designed to bypass logic and speak directly to your child's desires and emotions.

The earlier they're exposed, the deeper the impact.



How Food Marketing Gets Inside Your Child's Brain

Food companies targeting children don't just run advertisements — they run sophisticated psychological operations.

Understanding their three primary weapons helps you see what you're actually up against.



THE BOTTOM LINE

These strategies are designed to bypass logic and speak directly to your child's desires, emotions, and reward centers.

It's science. It's everywhere. And it works.

“

Awareness is the first step to breaking the cycle.

”

1 WEAPON 1: CHARACTERS & CARTOONS



Beloved characters create instant emotional bonds. Those feelings transfer to the product.

Their brain feels excitement, love, and familiarity — not a nutrition label.

HOW IT AFFECTS YOUR CHILD:

- Feels connected before food is even tasted
- Sees the food as fun, familiar, and safe
- Chooses based on emotion, not nutrition

2 WEAPON 2: REWARD PSYCHOLOGY



Toys, prizes, scratch cards, and collectibles trigger anticipation and excitement.

Junk food becomes linked to joy, celebration, and getting something special.

HOW IT AFFECTS YOUR CHILD:

- Craves the reward feeling
- Associates junk food with happiness
- Wants more to get more rewards

3 WEAPON 3: REPETITION & DIGITAL TARGETING



Children need 7–10 exposures before they begin wanting something.

Brands ensure constant exposure across screens, schools, friends, and even “kid-friendly” content.

HOW IT AFFECTS YOUR CHILD:

- Sees it everywhere
- Normalizes junk food as a daily choice
- Asks for it repeatedly



DID YOU KNOW?

A 2021 study found that children aged 2–11 are exposed to an average of 13 food and beverage advertisements per day, with over 80% of those ads promoting products high in sugar, fat, or sodium.



CHAPTER 1

SECTION 3

Why Willpower-Based Parenting Doesn't Work

Many parenting approaches feel logical. But when it comes to food, willpower and pressure often backfire.

Let's look at the most common strategies — and why they don't work.



THE TRUTH IS SIMPLE:

Restriction leads to obsession.
Control leads to rebellion.



Connection, understanding, and better strategies work **far better** than willpower and rules.

COMMON PARENTING APPROACHES



"Just one bite."

Forcing or persuading kids to try food they don't want.



"Finish your plate."

Encouraging kids to eat beyond fullness or ignore their body's cues.



"No dessert unless..."

Using food as a reward, bribe, or punishment.



"That's not allowed."

Banning certain foods or labelling them as 'bad' or 'junk'.



Pressure & Resistance

They feel pushed, not heard. This creates stress and emotional shutdown.



Disconnected from Fullness

They stop trusting their body and may overeat or undereat as they grow.



Food Becomes Conditional

They learn that love and rewards are tied to what (and how much) they eat.



Forbidden = More Appealing

They think about it more, crave it more, and binge when they get the chance.



THE TAKEAWAY

Willpower is limited. Connection is powerful.

When we move away from pressure and toward understanding, mealtimes become calmer, and kids build a healthier relationship with food.



CHAPTER 1

SECTION 4

What You Actually Control

If banning, pressuring, and stressing don't work — what does? The empowering truth is that while you cannot control what your child ultimately eats, you have enormous influence over the environment in which eating happens.

And environment, not willpower, is what shapes lifelong habits.



You control three things that genuinely matter:



1. The home food environment — what you stock, how you display food, and what eating looks and feels like in your house.



2. Your own language and emotional energy around food — whether mealtimes feel like battles or connections.



3. The experiences and exposures you create — markets, cooking together, growing things, exploring food with curiosity rather than obligation.



Every chapter in this book is built around one of these areas. Together, they form a practical, research-backed, guilt-free system for raising a child who is comfortable with healthy food — not because they've been forced, but because healthy eating has become a natural and enjoyable part of their world.



You don't need to be perfect. You need to be consistent, calm, and informed.
That's what this book is for.



THE TAKEAWAY

You can't control every bite your child takes. But you can control the environment, the energy, and the experiences that shape their choices every single day.

*Small choices.
Strong habits.
Healthy future.* ♥



Chapter Reflection

What This Chapter Was Really About

..  ..



1. Junk Food is Everywhere.

From ads to packaging to influencers, our children are surrounded by messages that promote junk food.



2. It's Designed to Influence.

Junk food companies use bright colors, fun characters, and smart marketing to grab attention and create cravings.



3. Awareness Gives Us Power.

When we understand how the system works, we can make smarter choices and take back control for our kids.

“ You can't shield your child from everything, but you can open their eyes to the truth. 



PAUSE & REFLECT

What part of this chapter felt most relevant to your family right now?



CHAPTER

1

SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Awareness today. Protection for tomorrow.



CHOOSE JUST ONE
to focus on this week

☐


BE AN OBSERVER.

Notice one junk food ad, message, or situation your child sees.
Awareness is the first step.

☐


READ ONE LABEL.

Pick any packaged snack or drink and read the ingredients together.
Knowledge empowers choices.

☐


REDUCE EXPOSURE.

Limit one source of junk food advertising or screen time this week.
Less exposure, less influence.

☐


TALK OPENLY.

Ask your child what they like about junk food and how ads try to make it look fun.
Connection builds understanding.

☐


WRITE IT DOWN.

Jot down one pattern you notice about junk food in your child's day.
Awareness turns into action.

TINY REFLECTION

Where do you notice junk food the most in your child's daily life?



PARENT REMINDER

You don't have to be perfect.
You just need to be aware.
The more you notice,
the more power you have to
protect your child's future. ♥

“ Junk food companies
spend billions to capture
your child's attention.
You have the power
to win it back. ”



**THIS WEEK I WILL
PRACTICE:**



Notice ads



Read labels



Reduce exposure



Talk openly



Write it down



RAISING KIDS IN A JUNK FOOD WORLD



CHAPTER 2

What 'Healthy Eating' Actually Means for Kids

Healthy eating isn't about perfect meals.

It's about better choices, most of the time.



Ditching perfection, understanding child nutrition basics, and redefining success at the table.



CHAPTER 2

SECTION 1



Letting Go of the Perfect Plate



Before we talk about what healthy eating actually looks like for children, we need to dismantle the image that most parents are silently trying to achieve — the perfectly balanced plate, the child who enthusiastically eats broccoli, the dinner table that looks like a well-lit wellness blog photograph.

That image is not real. And chasing it is quietly making you miserable.

Real healthy eating for children looks like this: some days they eat vegetables willingly; other days they refuse everything green. Some weeks they eat a wide variety; other weeks they eat the same four things on rotation. Some meals they finish enthusiastically; others they abandon after two bites. All of this is completely, developmentally normal.

The problem is not your child's eating. **The problem is the gap between what you expect and what is actually normal** — and that gap is the source of most mealtime misery.



REFRAME THIS

Your goal is not a child who eats perfectly at every meal. Your goal is a child who has a healthy, relaxed, curious relationship with food — one that will serve them for the rest of their life.



CHAPTER 2

SECTION 2



Understanding Child Nutrition Basics

You don't need a nutrition degree to feed your child well. You need a working understanding of a few foundational principles that, once understood, take enormous pressure off both of you.



Children Have Smaller Stomachs Than We Imagine

- A child's stomach is roughly the size of their fist. Small portions are filling. Full after a little? That's biology, not pickiness.



Growth Spurts Create Wildly Variable Appetites

- Appetite rises and falls with growth. Some days they eat a lot, some days little. Both are normal. Trust your child's hunger cues.



The Division of Responsibility

- You decide what, when, and where. Your child decides whether and how much. This removes mealtime power struggles.



Nutrients Over Foods

- Focus on nutrients, not forcing specific foods. No spinach? Offer other iron-rich options like dal, rajma, sesame seeds, or fortified cereals.



The Role of Fat and Carbohydrates in Child Development

- Kids need healthy fats for brain development (full-fat dairy, avocado, nuts, oils) and complex carbs for energy (rice, roti, oats, fruit). They fuel growth, not the enemy.



PRACTICAL NUTRITION PRINCIPLE

Aim for variety over perfection. A child who eats 20 different foods with moderate nutritional balance is in a far better position than a child who eats 5 'perfect' foods under enormous pressure.



CHAPTER 2

SECTION 3



Redefining Success at the Table

If 'success' at the table isn't a clean plate or enthusiastic vegetable consumption — what does it look like?
Here is a practical redefinition of mealtime success that most families find genuinely liberating:



Your child sat at the table for the meal without a battle — **success**

.....



Your child tried one new food, even if they didn't swallow it — **success**

.....



Your child expressed a preference without a meltdown ('I don't like that') — **success**

.....



Mealtime was calm and connected, regardless of what was eaten — **success**

.....



Your child helped prepare or set up any part of the meal — **success**

.....



You served a balanced variety and stayed calm about what was eaten — **success**

.....



Notice that none of these success markers require your child to eat a specific food or a specific amount. Success is about the relationship with food, the emotional environment of eating, and the gradual expansion of comfort and curiosity.

These are the foundations that lead to genuinely healthy eating in the long run.



CHAPTER 2

SECTION 4 ♥



What ‘Balance’ Really Means Day to Day

Balance in a child’s diet is not measured meal by meal — it’s measured across days and weeks. A nutritionist looking at what your child eats over a full week is far more relevant than what they ate at Tuesday’s lunch.

This means that if your child eats mostly carbohydrates on a busy Wednesday, that is fine — as long as their overall week includes protein, healthy fats, vegetables, and a variety of foods.

Stop evaluating individual meals. Start noticing patterns across weeks. This shift alone eliminates a significant portion of daily mealtime anxiety for most parents.



Mom’s Practical Test



Once a week, quickly review what your child ate. Did they eat something from each broad category — **protein, carbs, fats, fruit or vegetable** — at some point during the week?

If yes, you are doing well.

If not, gently add more variety next week.

That’s it.



Chapter Reflection

What This Chapter Was Really About



1. Routines Bring Security.

Regular mealtimes, sleep schedules, and daily rhythms help children feel safe and reduce anxiety around food choices.



2. Consistency Builds Healthy Habits.

When routines are consistent, healthy eating becomes automatic—not a daily struggle.



3. Structure Supports Better Choices.

A predictable structure reduces decision fatigue and helps kids make better choices with less conflict.

“

*Routines may feel repetitive to us,
but to our children, they feel like love.*

”



PAUSE & REFLECT

What part of your family's daily routine supports healthy eating the most?





Small Steps. Big Impact.



Simple actions you can take this week to create routines and a home environment that support healthy eating.



1. Set 3 Anchor Routines.

Pick three non-negotiable times each day for meals or snacks. Keep them consistent, even on busy days. Examples: Breakfast together, afternoon snack, family dinner.



2. Eat Together as Often as Possible.

Aim for at least one meal a day together without screens. Use this time to connect, not correct.



3. Plan Ahead, Reduce Decisions.

Plan meals and snacks in advance. Prep simple, healthy options so that good choices are easy and accessible.



4. Protect Sleep Routines.

Good sleep supports better appetite regulation and fewer food battles. Keep a consistent bedtime that works for your child.

“ Routines may feel repetitive to us, but to our children, they feel like love. ”



PAUSE & REFLECT

Which routine will you focus on improving this week?

.....

.....

.....



CHAPTER 3

The Home Food Environment



What you stock, how you display it,
and how your kitchen layout silently
shapes your child's choices.

Small
changes in
your kitchen
create big
changes in
their habits.



Good
food
Good
mood
♡



CHAPTER 3

SECTION 1 ♥

Your Home Is the Most Powerful Food Influence in Your Child's Life

Despite everything the food industry spends on marketing, your home food environment remains the single most powerful influence on what your child eats and how they relate to food. What is available, what is visible, how food is presented, and how eating is experienced in your home quietly programs your child's relationship with food — more than any advertisement, any school canteen, or any birthday party.



This is simultaneously the most overwhelming and most empowering truth in this book. Overwhelming because it means you matter enormously. Empowering because it means small, practical changes in your home environment can create significant, lasting change — without any battles, bargaining, or tears.



Home > Hype

No advertisement can compete with what your child experiences every day at home.



What's Around, Ends Up Down

The food that is available and visible at home shapes what your child naturally chooses.



Food Is Communication

The way food is offered, talked about, and enjoyed teaches your child more than any nutrition lesson.



Small Changes, Big Impact

Tiny shifts in your home environment today can shape your child's health and habits for years to come.



PRACTICAL NUTRITION PRINCIPLE

*You don't need to be perfect.
You just need to shape the environment
where healthy choices are easier,
more natural, and more enjoyable
for your child. ♥*



CHAPTER 3

SECTION 2 ♥



What You Stock – The Foundation

The simplest food environment principle is this: children eat what is available. If your kitchen is consistently stocked with a variety of nutritious foods, your child will eat a variety of nutritious foods. Not every day. Not without resistance. But consistently, over time, the available becomes the familiar, and the familiar becomes the preferred.



The Availability Principle

Remove the decision-making. When healthy food is visible, accessible, and ready to eat, it becomes the path of least resistance.

A bowl of washed fruit on the kitchen counter gets eaten. Fruit stored in the back of the refrigerator in a crisper drawer gets forgotten. Carrot sticks already cut and stored in a small container at eye level in the fridge disappear. Carrots that need washing, peeling, and cutting rarely get chosen when a biscuit packet is within reach.



80/20

The 80/20 Pantry Rule

A practical and sustainable approach to stocking your kitchen: aim for roughly 80% of your pantry to be whole, minimally processed foods, and allow 20% to be treats and convenience items.

This ratio ensures that the majority of what your child can access is nutritious, while acknowledging the reality that complete restriction creates desire and conflict.

The 80% does not need to be elaborate. Whole grains, lentils, seasonal vegetables, full-fat dairy, eggs, fruit, nuts, seeds, and legumes form the backbone of an extraordinarily nutritious pantry. Many of the healthiest foods in the Indian kitchen are also the simplest and least expensive.



The 'Always Available' List

Consider keeping these items available and accessible in your home at all times:

- ♥ A fruit bowl on the kitchen counter with 2–3 seasonal fruits
- ♥ Pre-washed and cut vegetables in a visible spot in the fridge
- ♥ A small container of soaked or roasted nuts/seeds at child eye level
- ♥ Cooked dal or legumes that can be eaten as a snack or light meal
- ♥ Curd/yoghurt in individual portions in the fridge
- ♥ Whole grain crackers or rotis that can be quickly served

♥ QUICK WIN

This week, rearrange one shelf in your refrigerator and one surface in your kitchen to make healthy food the most visible and accessible option. You will be surprised by the difference. ♥



CHAPTER 3



SECTION 3

How You Display Food — The Visibility Factor

Visibility is one of the most underestimated factors in what children eat. Research consistently shows that people — adults and children alike — eat more of what they can see. The implications for a family kitchen are significant.



Visible today,
healthy
tomorrow.



1

The Fruit Bowl Effect



Families with a visible fruit bowl on their counter consume significantly more fruit than families who store fruit in the refrigerator.

The act of seeing food triggers the consideration of eating it. When fruit is visible, it becomes part of the casual food landscape — something that can be picked up without any decision-making effort.



VISIBLE = MORE FRUIT EATEN



HIDDEN = LESS FRUIT EATEN

2

Child-Height Accessibility



In your refrigerator, designate one shelf or section as the “child zone” — positioned at your child’s eye level and containing only foods you are happy for them to help themselves to.

Pre-portioned yoghurt, fruit, cheese cubes, cooked vegetable sticks, and small containers of leftover dal work beautifully here. When a hungry child opens the fridge and immediately sees appealing, accessible options, they eat those options.



3

The Treat Visibility Reduction



This is not about hiding treats or creating forbidden foods — it is about reducing passive exposure.

When chips, biscuits, and sweets are stored in opaque containers at higher levels or in less-frequented areas, children don’t think about them constantly. Out of sight genuinely reduces out-of-mind craving.

When treats are displayed in open bowls or at eye level, they become a constant cognitive presence — your child’s brain is reminded of them every time they enter the kitchen.



ON DISPLAY = CONSTANT REMINDER



OUT OF SIGHT = OUT OF MIND



KEY TAKEAWAY

Show what you want your children to eat. Make healthy choices visible, accessible, and easy — and reduce the visibility of treats. Your kitchen environment shapes your child’s choices more than willpower ever could.



CHAPTER 3



SECTION 4 ♥

Kitchen Layout and Food Culture

Beyond what you stock and where you store it, the layout of your kitchen and the rituals around food create a lasting food culture your child will carry for life.



1

Make Cooking Visible

When children see cooking happening, food becomes interesting and familiar rather than mysterious or suspicious.



2

The Family Meal Table

Regular family meals build better eating habits, stronger connections, and healthier relationships with food. It's the ritual of eating together that matters most.



3

Your Plate as a Teaching Tool

Children copy what they see. When they watch you enjoy a variety of foods, they learn what is normal and desirable.



THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE



Eat one vegetable you genuinely enjoy in front of your child, with visible pleasure. Say nothing about nutrition. Just eat it, enjoy it, and let your child observe. Do this for five days. Note what happens.



Chapter Reflection

What This Chapter Was Really About

..  ..



1. Availability Shapes Choices.

When healthy foods are easy to see and reach, children are more likely to choose them naturally.



2. Visibility Influences Eating.

Out of sight often means out of mind. What's visible becomes the default choice for hungry kids.



3. Your Home Setup Matters.

A supportive food environment makes healthy eating easier, reduces power struggles, and builds lifelong habits.

“

Children eat what the environment repeatedly offers.

” 



PAUSE & REFLECT

What changes can you make in your home environment this week to support healthier choices for your child?





Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to create a food environment that naturally supports healthy choices.



1. Make Healthy Foods Easy to Find.

Keep fruits, vegetables, and healthy snacks at child eye level and within easy reach.



2. Plan Your Fridge & Pantry.

Stock your fridge and pantry with simple, whole foods so healthy choices are always available.



3. Create a Snack Station.

Offer 2-3 healthy snack options in one place so kids can choose independently.



4. Remove Daily Temptations.

Limit ultra-processed snacks and sugary drinks at home so they are not the default choice.

“

Children eat what the environment repeatedly offers.



PAUSE & REFLECT

Look around your home right now — what healthy foods are easy to find? What's one change you can make today to make healthy the easy choice?

.....

.....

.....

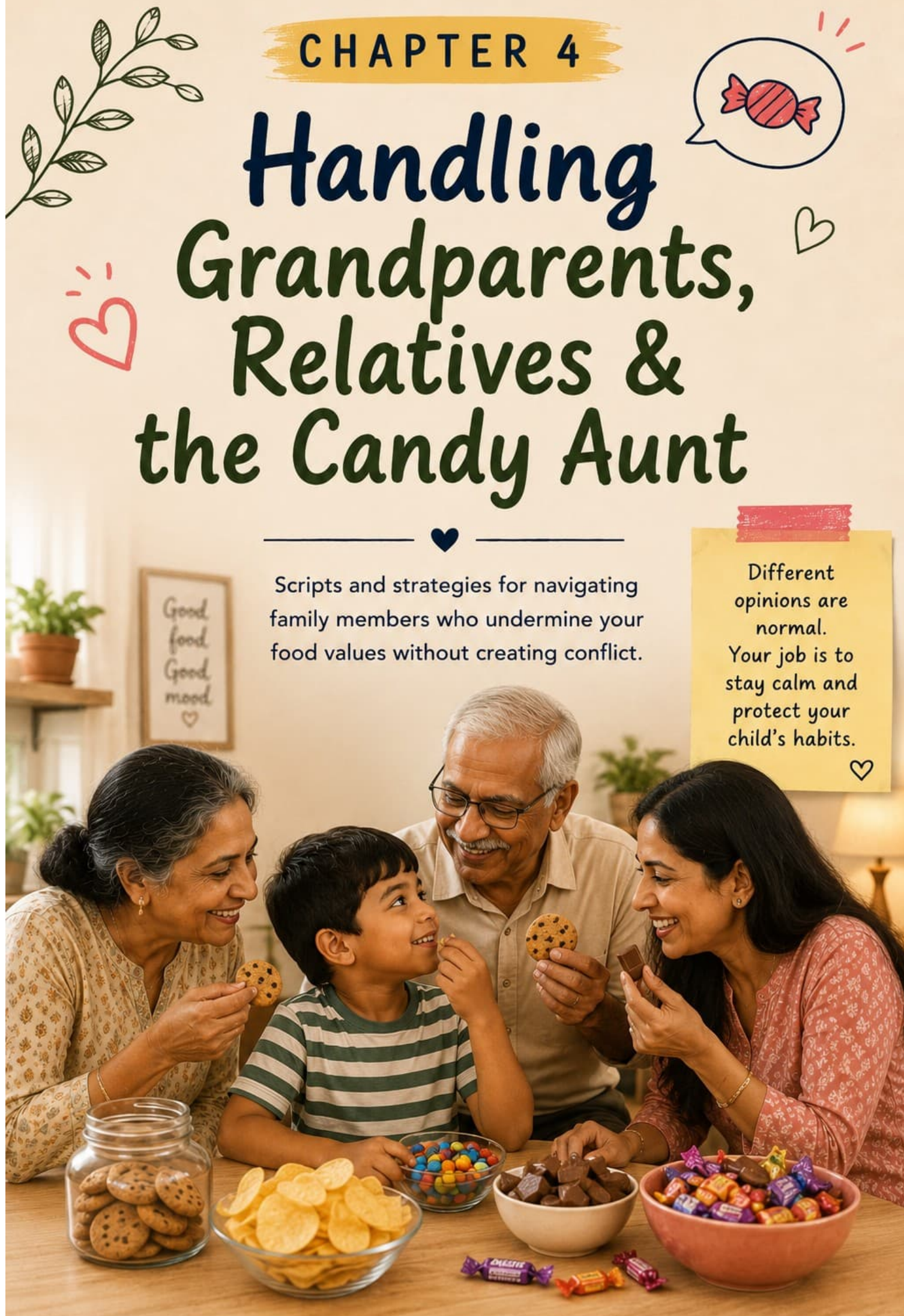


CHAPTER 4

Handling Grandparents, Relatives & the Candy Aunt

Scripts and strategies for navigating family members who undermine your food values without creating conflict.

Different opinions are normal. Your job is to stay calm and protect your child's habits.



CHAPTER 4

SECTION 1

The Family Food Politics Problem

You have done everything right. You've redesigned your pantry, introduced new foods with patience, created calm mealtimes — and then your child spends a weekend at their grandparents' home and comes back having eaten nothing but namkeen, mithai, and biscuits for two days straight. Or your sister-in-law slips your toddler a packet of chips five minutes before dinner. Or your mother-in-law declares that your healthy cooking is 'not enough' and supplements every meal with ghee-laden sweets.



Welcome to family food politics — one of the most emotionally charged and practically difficult aspects of raising children with intentional food values.

COMMON SCENARIOS



WEEKEND AT GRANDPARENTS' HOME

Child returns after eating mostly junk food for days.



Challenge: You lose control of what and how much your child eats.



THE PRE-DINNER TREAT

Relatives give snacks or sweets right before meals.



Challenge: It ruins appetite and sends mixed messages about boundaries.



THE "NOT ENOUGH" SUPPLEMENT

Relatives add extra ghee, sweets, or rich foods to every meal.



Challenge: Undermines your cooking and confuses your child.



THE REAL CHALLENGE

The challenge is not simply what the relatives are feeding your child. The challenge is navigating these situations without damaging relationships, without creating conflict at family gatherings, and without teaching your child that food is a battleground on which the people they love are taking opposing sides.



CHAPTER 4

SECTION 2

Understanding Why They Do It

Before developing strategies, it helps to understand what is actually happening when grandparents and relatives override your food preferences.

FOOD AS LOVE

For the generation of grandparents raising today's children, food was — and often still is — the primary love language. Offering food, especially sweet and special food, is an act of love, care, and celebration.

When your mother-in-law insists on feeding your child mithai, she is not trying to undermine your nutrition goals — she is trying to love your child in the way she knows best.

Understanding this reframes the dynamic and creates space for a more compassionate and effective response.

DIFFERENT GENERATIONAL NORMS

The previous generation raised children in a nutritional environment that was genuinely different. Processed food was less prevalent, portions were different, and the relationship between children and food was less medicalised.

'A little sugar never hurt anyone' was reasonable advice when children spent six hours a day running outside and processed food wasn't omnipresent. The conflict arises when yesterday's norms are applied to today's food landscape.

YOUR CHOICES AS IMPLICIT CRITICISM

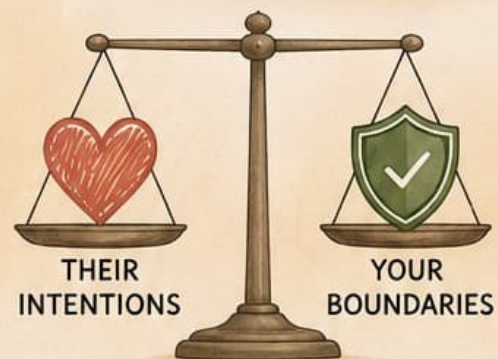
For relatives who raised children a certain way, a parent who makes different food choices can inadvertently communicate that the old way was wrong.

Your insistence on limiting sugar, avoiding processed snacks, and prioritising vegetables can feel like a criticism of their parenting — which triggers defensiveness and sometimes active resistance.

For them, food is love.

They grew up in a different time.

Your choices can feel like criticism of their parenting.



Empathy for their intentions.
Clarity in your boundaries.



CHAPTER 4

SECTION 3

Practical Scripts and Strategies



The goal is not to win every battle. The goal is to maintain the overall food culture you're building while preserving family harmony. Here are approaches that work.



1. CHOOSE YOUR MOMENTS

Not every food situation requires intervention. Occasional treats at grandparents' home are a normal part of childhood. Focus on patterns and principles, not individual incidents.



2. LEAD WITH APPRECIATION, NOT CORRECTION

Acknowledge their love and intention before addressing the food habit. Connection opens hearts; correction often creates resistance.



3. GIVE THEM A ROLE

Include relatives in your healthy food journey. Give them meaningful roles like cooking dal or introducing new fruits. When they feel included, they become allies.



4. THE "OUR DOCTOR SAID" SCRIPT

Use your paediatrician as a shared reference. It removes the conflict and shifts the focus to the child's wellbeing. Grandparents respond better to a doctor's advice.



Love, connection and balance — that's the goal.



5. PRACTICAL BOUNDARIES THAT WORK



Offer treats after meals, not before.



Keep approved treats at their home so they have a healthy option ready.



Set one clear, non-negotiable rule (e.g., no screens during eating) and be flexible about the rest.



Have a private conversation with your partner first and present a united front.



REMEMBER



Treats at grandparents' home are not a nutritional failure — they are a relationship success.

The goal is a loving family, variety in experiences, and a healthy baseline at home.





CHAPTER 4

SECTION 4

When It's More Serious



Occasionally, family food interference crosses from occasional treats into genuinely problematic territory — feeding a child with a known allergy something that triggers it, consistently undermining medical dietary advice, or using food as control or emotional manipulation with the child.

IN THESE CASES, CLEARER AND FIRMER BOUNDARIES ARE NECESSARY.



Food allergies must be taken seriously.



Medical dietary advice should be respected.



Food should never be used to control or manipulate.



Involve your partner and, when needed, your child's paediatrician as an authority in these conversations.

Clear boundaries protect your child's health and well-being.



WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE



Have calm but firm conversations. Be clear about what is non-negotiable.



Present a united front with your partner. Consistency is key.



Use professional guidance when needed. A paediatrician's advice carries weight.



Protecting your child's health is not rude — it is your responsibility.



For Most Families, Perspective is the Solution

Perfection is not the goal — connection is.

- Children are remarkably resilient.
- A healthy food baseline at home matters most.
- A relaxed, curious relationship with food builds confidence.
- A family environment filled with love and togetherness leaves the deepest impact.



The occasional mithai from a doting grandmother won't undo what you're building every day.



Love, consistency, and balance — that's what your child remembers.





Chapter Reflection

What This Chapter Was Really About



1. Grandparents Feed With Love.

Food is often how grandparents express affection, comfort, and care in ways that children deeply feel.



2. Collaboration Works Better Than Conflict.

Children thrive when parents and grandparents work together with respect and understanding instead of battling over food.



3. Relationships Matter More Than Perfect Meals.

Protecting emotional connection creates a safe, joyful food environment that lasts far beyond childhood.

“ Protect the relationship first. 



PAUSE & REFLECT

What food memories from your own childhood still feel comforting today?





Small Steps. Big Impact.



Simple actions you can take this week to strengthen your child's bond with grandparents and create a loving food environment.



1. Appreciate Their Love.

Acknowledge the care, time, and effort grandparents put into feeding and nurturing your child. Gratitude builds connection.



2. Communicate & Collaborate.

Talk openly with grandparents about your child's needs and preferences. Together is always better than tension.



3. Create Shared Food Traditions.

Build simple traditions together—family recipes, weekend treats, or festival foods that everyone looks forward to.



4. Protect the Relationship First.

It's okay to let go of small battles. A happy relationship today creates a healthier food environment for your child tomorrow.

“

*Protect the relationship first.
The food will follow.*



PAUSE & REFLECT

What food memories from your own childhood still feel comforting today?





CHAPTER 5

Birthday Parties, Functions & the Holiday Spiral



How to handle high-sugar events without
banning treats or raising a kid who
secretly binges at friends' houses



Balance,
not restriction.
Connection,
not control.
Memories,
not perfection.



CHAPTER 5

SECTION 1

The Event Food Problem



Birthdays, festivals, holidays—these events are packed with exactly the foods we try to limit every day. The challenge isn't the food. It's how we think about it.



IT'S A CONCENTRATED DOSE

Cakes, sweets, chips, cold drinks, fried snacks, and candy appear in large quantities that would be alarming on a regular Tuesday.



IT CAN FEEL LIKE ALL PROGRESS IS LOST

For parents working hard to build healthy habits, it can feel like all your efforts are undone in just a few hours.



THE HARDER YOU CONTROL, THE WORSE IT GETS

Strict rules create tension and push kids to obsess over the very foods you restrict.



A DIFFERENT PHILOSOPHY IS THE SOLUTION

It's not about stricter control. It's about perspective, balance, and trust.

Our goal is balance.
Not perfection.



CHAPTER 5

SECTION 2 ♥

Why 'Sometimes Foods' Is the Right Framework

The most effective framework for managing event food with children is the 'sometimes foods and everyday foods' distinction.

This simple language, used consistently from toddlerhood, gives children a cognitive category for treats that doesn't make those treats forbidden, shameful, or desperately desirable.



EVERYDAY FOODS

What we eat most of the time because they help our bodies grow and feel good.



SOMETIMES FOODS

What we eat at parties, celebrations, and special occasions — they're delicious and fun, and they're a normal part of life.



Children who grow up with this framework don't binge at parties because treats aren't forbidden — they're just appropriately categorised. They know what a party food is, they enjoy it at the party, and they return to their normal eating pattern without drama because there is no deprivation to compensate for.

Party foods
are fun and
delicious.

They're for special
occasions.

I can enjoy them
and still make
healthy choices
every day.



CHAPTER 5

SECTION 3 ♥

Before the Event

Preparation before high-sugar events significantly reduces both the stress of the event and the likelihood of post-event nutritional chaos.



FEED BEFORE YOU GO

Never send a hungry child to a birthday party. A child who arrives at a party already reasonably satisfied will make more moderate choices from the snack table. A child who arrives hungry will eat everything in sight with the focused intensity of someone who hasn't seen food in days.



A small, satisfying meal or snack — roti and dal, a bowl of curd with fruit, some nuts and cheese — before the event is one of the simplest and most effective party-food strategies available.



HAVE THE CONVERSATION IN ADVANCE

For children over age 4, a brief, casual pre-event conversation sets expectations without creating rules.

“There’s going to be lots of yummy party food today. You can have some cake and some snacks — it’s a celebration! And we’ll have a proper dinner when we get home.”



This acknowledges the reality, gives permission, and establishes the broader context, all without pressure or restriction.



A little preparation today
leads to a more joyful event
and a calmer tomorrow.



CHAPTER 5

SECTION 4 ♥

During the Event

Your goal during the event is to stay calm and stay out of the way.



LET THEM ENJOY WITHOUT COMMENT

Let your child eat party food without comment, counting, or visible concern. The moment you begin monitoring, restricting, or reacting to what your child eats at a party, the food becomes the central drama — and drama makes food more desirable, not less. Trust the framework you've built at home. Trust that one party's worth of treats will not undo months of thoughtful food culture.



GUIDE GENTLY, NOT STRICTLY



If your child is very young (under 3), it's reasonable to gently guide portions — not by refusing food, but by managing their plate before they reach the table.



For older children, allow them to make their own choices within the event context.



One party won't undo your work.
Trust the foundation.
Stay calm. Stay present.
Let them enjoy.



CHAPTER 5

SECTION 5 ♥

After the Event — The Holiday Spiral and How to Break It

The 'holiday spiral' describes what happens when one food event leads to another, and another, and before you know it your child has spent three weeks eating almost exclusively festival sweets, party snacks, and celebratory treats.

In India, where festivals occur frequently and often in clusters, this is a genuine challenge.



THE 24-HOUR RESET

After any high-sugar event, simply return to your regular eating pattern the next morning. Don't announce a 'health kick.' Don't make the previous day's eating sound like a problem. Just serve breakfast as you normally would, proceed with your regular meal schedule, and let the contrast re-establish itself naturally. Most children slot back into their everyday food rhythm quickly when there's no drama around the transition.



THE FESTIVAL FOOD STRATEGY

During festival seasons, rather than trying to limit sweets completely, make a few strategic adjustments to compensate:



Increase protein and fibre at main meals.



Ensure proper hydration.



Keep fruit and nuts visible and accessible.



Reduce screen time (which, as we'll discuss in Chapter 9, is directly linked to food craving).

These adjustments provide nutritional counterbalance without turning the festival into a battleground.



THE BIGGER PICTURE



A child who eats freely at festivals and returns easily to nutritious everyday eating has exactly the relationship with food you're trying to build.

Flexibility is not failure —
it is the goal.



Chapter Reflection



Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to help your child enjoy birthday parties and social eating with confidence and balance.



1. Prepare, Don't Over-Plan.

Talk to your child about the party, what foods might be there, and remind them they can listen to their hunger and fullness.



2. Focus on Fun & Connection.

Teach your child that parties are about people, games, and joy—food is just one part of it.



3. Encourage Balanced Choices.

It's okay to enjoy treats! Help your child choose what they like, try new things, and stop when they feel full.



4. Stay Calm, Stay Positive.

Avoid food rules or guilt after parties. Trust your child's body and praise their efforts to make kind and healthy choices.

“

*Celebrate today. Build confidence for tomorrow.
Happy memories matter more than perfect eating.*



PAUSE & REFLECT

How can you support your child to enjoy parties and social eating while feeling good about food?





Small Steps. Big Impact.



Simple actions you can take this week to make birthday parties joyful, memorable, and supportive of healthy choices.



1. Plan with Purpose.

Choose a fun theme and plan activities your child enjoys. Include healthy foods and drinks so everyone feels their best.



2. Focus on Fun, Not Just Food.

Make games, music, and connection the highlights. Happy memories come from experience, not just the menu.



3. Offer Balanced Choices.

Serve a variety of colorful foods—fruits, veggies, whole grains, and treats. It's okay to enjoy a little sweetness in moderation.



4. Make It Meaningful.

Encourage kindness and gratitude. Thank guests, include others, and teach your child that celebrations are about love and sharing.

“

*A birthday is a celebration of love today
and the foundation for healthy habits tomorrow.*



PAUSE & REFLECT

What kind of birthday celebrations or social meals help your child feel included, happy, and comfortable with food?



CHAPTER 6

What to Do When Your Kid Only Wants Fast Food



It's not about
being perfect.
It's about
making better
choices,
together. ♥

Understanding the pull of ultra-processed food,
gradual exposure techniques,
and fast food harm reduction.



CHAPTER 6

SECTION 1

Why Ultra-Processed Food Is Genuinely Addictive

If your child seems almost unnaturally drawn to fast food, chips, instant noodles, and packaged snacks — to the point where other foods seem to generate little or no interest — you are not dealing with a preference. You may be dealing with something that functions more like a **learned craving**.



- SALT
- SUGAR
- FAT
- FLAVOUR ENHANCERS

Ultra-processed foods are specifically engineered to be maximally stimulating to the human palate. Food scientists work to identify the precise combinations of salt, sugar, fat, and flavour enhancers that create what the industry calls '**hyperpalatability**' — a level of taste stimulation so intense that it makes natural, whole foods seem bland and uninteresting by comparison.

HYPERPALATABILITY

High taste stimulation



LOW TASTE STIMULATION

Natural, whole foods



YOUNG PALATE IN DEVELOPMENT

When children eat these foods regularly from a young age, their palate calibrates to expect this level of stimulation. A plain rice dish or a vegetable sabzi genuinely tastes less interesting to them — not because they are being difficult, but because their taste experience has been set to a **different standard**.

EXPECTATION SET HIGH



Needs intense flavours to feel satisfied.

NATURAL FOODS SEEM BLAND



Plain, wholesome foods seem less interesting.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Ultra-processed foods hijack our brain's reward system, creating cravings and setting a new normal that's hard to break.



THE GOAL

Help children reset their palate, rediscover real food, and build a healthier relationship with eating.



CHAPTER 6

SECTION 2

Understanding the Pull

Fast food and junk food are not simply tasty. They are designed to be consumed quickly, eaten in large quantities, and craved again shortly after. Understanding the specific mechanisms at work helps parents respond more effectively.



1 The Salt-Fat-Sugar Combination

The combination of high salt, high fat, and high sugar in a single food item is essentially non-existent in nature. Natural foods are either sweet, or savoury, or fatty — but rarely all three simultaneously at high intensity.

When children encounter this combination — in a packet of masala chips, for example — it triggers a reward response in the brain that is genuinely more intense than the response triggered by whole foods.



This is not a character flaw in your child. It is their brain responding normally to an **abnormal stimulus**.

2 The Speed and Ease Factor

Fast food is called fast food for a reason. It requires no waiting, no preparation, no uncertainty about taste, and no effort. For a hungry child, this is enormously appealing.



Part of the solution lies in ensuring that healthy food is equally fast, equally easy to access, and equally certain in its flavour — which is why **Chapter 3's** environment design work is so foundational.

FAST FOOD



No waiting



No preparation



No uncertainty



No effort

VS.

HEALTHY FOOD



✓ Ready to eat

✓ Pre-prepped

✓ Consistent taste

✓ Easy to access



CHAPTER 6

SECTION 3

Gradual Exposure Techniques

The goal is not to eliminate fast food from your child's life permanently. The goal is to expand their palate so that fast food is one option among many they genuinely enjoy — rather than the only option that feels satisfying.



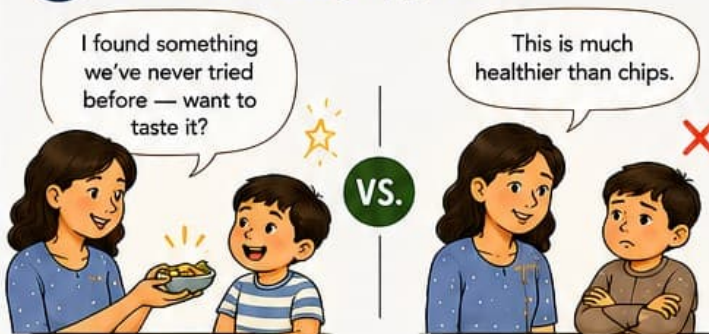
1 The Bridge Food Method



Bridge foods are homemade versions of your child's favourite fast foods, made with better ingredients and progressively modified toward more nutritious versions.

If your child loves chips, start with homemade baked chips. Over several months, introduce variations — sweet potato chips, baked lotus root chips, roasted makhana. The familiar format (crunchy, salty, snackable) provides the comfort while the ingredient gradually changes.

2 The Curiosity Approach



Instead of presenting new healthy foods as 'better' alternatives to fast food — which your child will immediately categorise as inferior — present them as entirely new experiences.

- 😊 "I found something we've never tried before — want to taste it?" generates curiosity.
- 😞 "This is much healthier than chips" generates resistance.

★ Frame new nutritious foods as adventures, not replacements.

3 The Repeated Neutral Exposure Principle



Research in feeding therapy shows that children need 10–15 neutral exposures to a new food before they begin accepting it.

A neutral exposure means the food is present on the table, accessible to taste, and not accompanied by any pressure, comment, or emotional investment from the parent. The food simply exists in the child's environment, available to explore at their own pace.

🌿 This is a slow process — it is also the only process that reliably works.



CHAPTER 6

SECTION 4

Fast Food Harm Reduction

There will be times when fast food is what's available — travel, late evenings, celebrations, convenience. Harm reduction strategies help minimise nutritional impact without creating guilt or conflict.



Better choices,
better balance.

Small changes,
big difference.

Mindful eating,
happy me.



- 1 Choose grilled options over fried where available



- 2 Add a side of fresh fruit or salad to any fast food meal



- 3 Choose water or nimbu pani over cold drinks consistently



- 4 Order smaller portions — children rarely need adult-sized fast food portions



- 5 Make fast food a sit-down, family experience rather than a rushed grab — eating slowly and mindfully reduces overconsumption



- 6 Follow a fast food meal with a nutritionally dense next meal — a vegetable-rich khichdi or dal-rice dinner resets the balance effectively

Harm Reduction Mindset



The goal is not zero fast food. The goal is a child who can enjoy fast food without it being their only source of food pleasure, and whose overall diet provides the nutrition they need to thrive.



Chapter Reflection

Let's Pause & Think!

Take a moment to look back at what you've learned and how you can apply it in your family life.



“

Smart choices today build healthy habits, happy moments, and a stronger tomorrow.



PAUSE & REFLECT

How can your family make smarter fast food and eating out choices together this month?



Simple actions you can take this week to make smarter choices when enjoying fast food or eating out with confidence and balance.



1. Plan & Choose Wisely.

Check menus online, look for healthier options, and decide before you go. Planning ahead helps you make choices you'll feel good about.



2. Practice Portion Balance.

Enjoy your favorites without overdoing it. Share, choose smaller sizes, and balance your meal with fruits or veggies.



3. Choose Healthier Swaps.

Pick grilled over fried, water or unsweetened drinks, and add more veggies. Small swaps make a big difference.



4. Listen to Your Body.

Notice when you're full, eat mindfully, and stop when enough. It's okay to save some for later and enjoy slowly.





Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to make eating out easier, healthier, and less stressful.



1. Check The Menu First.

Look at the menu before leaving home. Choose 1–2 options that fit your family's goals.



2. Add One Better Choice.

When eating out, add just one nutritious item:

- fruit
- vegetables
- salad
- yoghurt

Small additions matter.



3. Choose Water First.

Make water the default drink. Save sugary drinks for occasional treats.



4. Share When Possible.

Share large portions, fries, desserts, or snacks. Children usually need far less than restaurant serving sizes.



5. Focus On The Experience.

Talk, laugh, and connect. The goal isn't a perfect meal. The goal is an enjoyable family experience.

“ A meal out should create memories, not guilt. ”

PAUSE & REFLECT

Which one restaurant habit could your family improve this month?



CHAPTER 7

Talking to Kids About Food Without Creating Food Issues



— ♥ —
Age-appropriate language
around nutrition, weight, and
healthy bodies that builds
confidence, not anxiety.

Kind words
today,
confident
kids
tomorrow.





CHAPTER 7

SECTION 1

The Words We Use Shape the Relationship



The language parents use around food is one of the most powerful and least discussed influences on children's long-term relationship with eating. Children are not just listening to what we say — they are absorbing our emotional relationship with food, our beliefs about bodies, and our associations between eating and worthiness.



Parents who grew up in households where food was laden with moral judgment — 'good foods' and 'bad foods', 'eating well' versus 'cheating', guilt around certain foods, pride around restriction — often unconsciously replicate this language with their own children, even when they consciously want to do differently.



This chapter gives you the specific language tools to talk about food in ways that build your child's confidence, curiosity, and healthy relationship with their body.



1

Words matter more than we think.

Children absorb the tone, emotion and meaning behind our words about food.



2

Avoid labeling foods as 'good' or 'bad'.

All foods can fit — the context and balance matter.



3

Focus on how food helps, not how it looks.

Talk about energy, strength, growth, concentration and feeling good.



4

Separate food from emotions.

Avoid using food as a reward, comfort or punishment.



5

Model a healthy relationship with food.

Children learn more from what we do than what we say.



6

Build body respect and gratitude.

Encourage kids to appreciate what their bodies can do, not how they look.



Language That Builds Up



"This food gives your body energy to play and learn."



"Every body is different and that's what makes us amazing."



"It's okay to enjoy all kinds of foods in balance."



"How does this food make your body feel?"



"You get to decide how much is enough for you."



"I love how strong/creative/kind your body helps you be!"





CHAPTER 7

SECTION 2

Language to Avoid and Why



'Good Food' and 'Bad Food'



Labeling foods as good or bad makes children judge themselves. Eating a 'bad food' can create shame, guilt, and secret eating.

Use neutral, functional language:



'Everyday foods'
& 'Sometimes foods'



'Growing foods'
& 'Celebration foods'



"You Need to Eat That"



Obligation creates resistance. Vegetables become a burden instead of something to enjoy.



"You need to eat your vegetables."



Invite & explore:

"This vegetable is crunchy — want to try it?"

"I wonder how this would taste with the dal."



Clean Plate Praise



Praising finishing the plate teaches children to ignore fullness and eat for approval.



"Good job eating everything!"



Praise what you want:

- ♥ Trying something new
- ♥ Sitting at the table
- ♥ Good manners
- ♥ Saying "I'm full" politely



Body Comments — Positive and Negative

Comments about a child's body — even positive ones — teach them their body is for evaluation. This can lead to body dissatisfaction and disordered eating.



"You're getting so slim!"
"You have such a healthy appetite!"



Focus on what bodies do:

"Your strong legs helped you run so fast today!"



Children remember the feeling behind food conversations far longer than the exact words.





CHAPTER 7

SECTION 3

Language to Use – Age by Age



1

Ages 2–4: Simple, Sensory, Playful

Young children respond to sensory descriptions and simple function explanations. “This is crunchy — can you hear it when you bite?” and “This orange food helps your eyes see clearly” are age-appropriate and interesting. Keep language playful, never pressured.



This is crunchy!
Can you hear it? 



Orange foods
help your eyes
see clearly. 



Food gives your
body energy to
play and grow! 

2

Ages 5–8: Function and Choice

School-age children can understand basic nutrition concepts framed around what they care about. “Dal has protein — that’s what helps your muscles get strong when you play cricket” connects food to something that matters to them. Offer genuine choice wherever possible: “Would you like carrot sticks or cucumber with your snack today?” Choice builds autonomy and reduces resistance.



Dal has protein —
that’s what helps your
muscles get strong
when you play cricket.



Would you like
carrot sticks or
cucumber with your
snack today? 



Food helps your body
play, learn and think
all day! 

3

Ages 9–12: Honest Conversation

Older children can handle more nuanced conversations about nutrition, including why some foods are marketed more heavily than others, how food companies make money, and how to read a simple ingredient list. These conversations build media literacy and critical thinking alongside nutritional understanding.



Why are some
foods advertised
more than others?



Let’s read the
ingredients
together. 



Food companies
design foods to
keep us wanting
more.



Children learn best when food conversations
evolve with their age, curiosity, and independence. 





CHAPTER 7

SECTION 4



Talking About Weight and Body Size



If your child is concerned about their weight or body size — whether due to comments from peers, comparisons to siblings, or their own observations — this requires careful, compassionate navigation.



1. Compassionate Response

Never confirm or dismiss their concern. Instead, redirect to function and strength.

“Bodies come in all shapes and sizes — what matters is that your body is healthy and strong. What does your body do well?”



2. Focus on Function

Shift attention from how the body looks to what it can do.

✓ Your body helps you run, play and grow.



✓ What does your body do well?

✓ Healthy bodies look different on everyone.



3. Medical Guidance

For children with genuine medical concerns about weight, all conversations should be guided by a paediatrician.

Frame discussions around:



Health



Energy



Strength



Never focus on appearance or make comparisons with others.



Language That Lasts



The goal is a child who grows into an adult who eats intuitively, appreciates their body, and enjoys food without guilt.



That adult is built word by word, meal by meal, in the ordinary conversations of childhood.



The way children feel about their bodies is shaped quietly through everyday conversations. ♥



Chapter Reflection

TALKING TO KIDS ABOUT FOOD



“

The goal is not to control what children eat today.

The goal is to teach them how to think about food for life.



PAUSE & REFLECT

What food message do you want your child to carry into adulthood?

.....

.....

.....

What This Chapter Was Really About



1. Children Learn Through Conversation.

The words we use around food shape how children think and feel about eating.



2. Curiosity Works Better Than Control.

Questions and exploration build confidence far better than pressure or rules.



3. Food Should Never Carry Shame.

Children thrive when food is discussed with balance, kindness, and perspective.



RAISING KIDS IN A JUNK FOOD WORLD





“ The conversations around food matter as much as the food itself. ♥

Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to build healthier conversations around food.



1. Describe Food Neutrally.

Avoid labels like:

- good food
- bad food
- junk food

Instead say:

- everyday foods
- sometimes foods



2. Ask More Questions.

Try:

- “What do you notice about this food?”
- “How does it taste?”
- “What does it remind you of?”

Curiosity builds confidence.



3. Talk About How Food Helps.

Connect food to:

- energy
- growth
- learning
- play

Not weight or appearance.



4. Respect Fullness Signals.

When your child says they're full: Pause.

Listen.

Trust them.



5. Model Positive Food Talk.

Let children hear:

- ✓ “This gives me energy.”
- ✓ “I enjoy eating vegetables.”
- ✓ “All foods can fit.”



PAUSE & REFLECT

Which food message do you want your child to hear more often at home?



RAISING KIDS IN A JUNK FOOD WORLD



CHAPTER 8

Building Food Curiosity at Home

Farmers markets, cooking together, growing herbs — low-effort ways to expand their world beyond chicken nuggets.



CHAPTER 8

SECTION 1

Curiosity Is the Antidote to Pickiness

Picky eating is, at its core, a relationship with food defined by suspicion and avoidance. The antidote to suspicion is curiosity — and curiosity is built through low-pressure, multi-sensory experiences with food that have nothing to do with eating.

A child who has grown a tomato plant on the balcony is not suspicious of tomatoes. A child who has kneaded roti dough with their grandmother is not afraid of wheat flour. A child who has visited a vegetable market and chosen something unfamiliar to bring home is primed to at least taste what they selected. Curiosity is built through engagement with food in contexts that are entirely separate from the pressure of the meal table.

1 Curiosity vs Suspicion



Picky eating often comes from suspicion and avoidance.

Curiosity lowers fear naturally.

“Curiosity is built before food ever reaches the plate.”

2 Multi-Sensory Experiences



✓ Grow something



✓ Touch and smell ingredients



✓ Let them choose unfamiliar foods



✓ Cook together without pressure

3 Low Pressure Matters



Curiosity grows outside pressured eating moments.

Engagement matters more than forcing bites.

Connection today, openness tomorrow.



Children are more willing to taste foods they already feel connected to.

CHAPTER 8

SECTION 2

The Market Experience

1 The Selection Game

Give your child one choice per market visit: 'Pick one vegetable you've never tried and we'll cook it this week.' This simple game builds agency, curiosity, and investment in the result.



"Children are more willing to taste foods they helped choose."

Examples of exciting picks:



Purple cauliflower



Cherry tomatoes



Baby corn



Red spinach

2 Ask Questions, Don't Lecture

At the market, narrate with curiosity rather than information delivery.



"Do you think this tastes sweet or spicy?"

"What color do you think it is inside?"

"Which vegetable looks funniest today?"

These questions engage the child's own sensory curiosity. Curiosity works better than lectures!

3 Markets as Adventure



- ✓ Touch different textures
- ✓ Smell new aromas
- ✓ Explore shapes and sizes
- ✓ Compare colors
- ✓ Make food discovery exciting and fun!

Food curiosity grows fastest when children feel involved, not instructed.

CHAPTER 8

SECTION 3

Cooking Together

1 Why Cooking Together Matters

Research shows that children who cook with their parents eat a wider variety of foods and have more positive relationships with eating.

Involvement creates investment.



“Kids are more likely to try foods they helped make.”



2 Age-Appropriate Kitchen Roles

Ages 2-3



- ✓ Wash vegetables
- ✓ Tear lettuce
- ✓ Stir ingredients



Ages 4-5



- ✓ Mash foods
- ✓ Pour ingredients
- ✓ Decorate dishes



Ages 6-8



- ✓ Mix batter
- ✓ Make sandwiches
- ✓ Simple chopping



Ages 9-12



- ✓ Follow recipes
- ✓ Make breakfast
- ✓ Supervised stovetop cooking



3 The Messy Kitchen Rule



Cooking with children is messy. Flour on the floor. Unevenly chopped vegetables. Batter over-stirred.

If your priority is a perfectly clean kitchen and perfect food, it will feel frustrating.

If your priority is a child who is curious, engaged, and building a lifelong relationship with cooking, the mess is completely worth it.

Decide in advance which you're prioritising, and let that decision govern your emotional response.

“A messy kitchen can build a lifelong relationship with food.”



Connection in the kitchen often matters more than what ends up on the plate.

CHAPTER 8

SECTION 4

Growing Food

1 Why Growing Food Matters

Growing even a single edible plant — a tomato, fresh coriander, mint, or a chilli — creates a food connection that is genuinely difficult to replicate through any other means.

A child who has watched something grow from a seed to something edible has had a profound experience of where food comes from and what it takes to produce it.



“A child who grows food sees it differently on the plate.”

2 You Don't Need a Garden

You do not need a garden.
Small spaces are enough.



✓ Balcony tomato pot



Mint on kitchen counter



Sprouting moong beans



Coriander in a small tray

✓ The process matters more than the scale.

3 Connection Through Care



- ✓ Watering
- ✓ Watching growth
- ✓ Smelling herbs
- ✓ Picking leaves
- ✓ Using them in cooking



“Food becomes familiar when children help care for it.”



Even one tiny plant can change how a child sees food forever.

CHAPTER 8

SECTION 5

Food Stories and Cultural Connection

Food is one of the richest entry points into cultural identity, family history, and connection across generations.

1 Food Carries Stories

When children know the stories behind the food, they feel connected to their family, their culture and their roots.



“ Food becomes meaningful when children know the story behind it. ”

2 Cultural Connection

Food is more than nutrition. It carries memory, culture and belonging.



✓ Grandmother's dal recipe



✓ Festival sweets tradition



✓ Regional dishes from family roots



✓ Cooking together across generations

3 This Month's Project

Three simple experiences. Do each once. Spark curiosity that lasts far longer than lectures.

Grow one plant



Grow even a single pot of coriander, mint or any herb.

Market adventure



Let your child choose one new vegetable to explore together.

Cooking together



Let them make one component of one meal.

♥ Small food experiences create lasting curiosity. ”

♥ Why Food Stories Matter

- ♥ Builds identity and self-esteem
- ♥ Creates belonging and connection
- ♥ Encourages adventurous eating
- ♥ Strengthens family bonds
- ♥ Preserves traditions and values



Children who grow up with food stories carry a deeper, warmer relationship with eating.

Chapter Reflection



What This Chapter Was Really About



1. Curiosity Comes Before Eating

Children often need to explore food long before they are willing to taste it.



2. Exposure Builds Familiarity

Seeing, touching, smelling, and helping with food are all valuable forms of learning.



3. Small Interactions Create Big Change

Tiny moments of food exploration often lead to long-term acceptance.

“

Children don't need pressure to explore food. They need opportunities.



PAUSE & REFLECT

Which food could your child explore this week without any pressure to eat it?

.....

.....

.....





“ Every touch, smell, and question is a step toward acceptance. ”



PAUSE & REFLECT

Which food activity would your child enjoy most: touching, smelling, helping cook, or choosing ingredients?

Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to build food curiosity at home.



1. Invite, Don't Insist.

Offer new foods without pressure. Let your child decide if and how much to engage with it.



2. Explore in Many Ways.

Encourage looking, touching, smelling, squishing, and even playing with food.



3. Involve Them in the Process.

Let children help with small tasks like washing, mixing, stirring, arranging, or choosing.



4. Be Consistently Exposed.

Keep offering a variety of foods regularly. Familiarity grows comfort over time.



5. Celebrate Small Steps.

Notice and appreciate curiosity—not just tasting. Every interaction is progress.



CHAPTER 9

Screen Time & Food – The Hidden Connection



How ads, YouTube, and even kids' shows influence food cravings, and practical ways to counter it.



RAISING KIDS IN A JUNK FOOD WORLD



CHAPTER 9

SECTION 1

The Screen-Craving Loop

Children who spend more time around screens tend to crave more ultra-processed foods, eat more mindlessly, and become less responsive to hunger cues.



“Screens don’t just entertain — they shape cravings.”

THE 3-PART LOOP

1



FOOD ADVERTISING

Repeated exposure to food ads increases cravings and normalizes junk food.

2



DISTRACTED EATING

Screens reduce awareness of fullness, leading children to eat more automatically.

3



REWARD LOOP

Fast-paced entertainment and hyper-palatable foods stimulate the brain’s reward system together.



Children often crave what they repeatedly see, hear, and associate with comfort.



CHAPTER 9

SECTION 2

Mechanism 1 — Direct Food Advertising

Children are exposed to hundreds of food advertisements every week — most promoting ultra-processed foods high in sugar, salt, and fat.

1



TV ADVERTISING

Television still exposes children to repeated junk food messaging.

2



DIGITAL ADVERTISING

Ads now appear inside games, YouTube videos, influencer content, and social feeds.

3



CHILDREN DON'T RECOGNIZE PERSUASION

Children under 8 often experience advertising as information, not marketing.



“Children absorb food messaging long before they learn to question it.”



Unlike television advertising, which is regulated and broadcast at known times, digital advertising is personalised, continuous, and often invisible. It appears as pre-rolls, sponsored posts, influencer challenges, product placements in games, and more.



Repeated exposure quietly shapes cravings, preferences, and food expectations.



CHAPTER 9

SECTION 3

Mechanism 2 – Mindless Eating

Children who eat while watching screens often consume more food, eat faster, and feel less satisfied afterward.

1



DISTRACTED BRAIN

The brain struggles to notice fullness signals while attention is focused on screens.

2



FASTER EATING

Children tend to eat more quickly and automatically during screen time.

3



REDUCED SATISFACTION

Mindless eating reduces meal awareness, making children feel hungry again sooner.



“Screens compete with the brain’s ability to notice hunger and fullness.”

SCREEN



Attention is captured by the screen.

DISTRACTION



Focus shifts away from internal body cues.

LESS SATIETY



Fullness signals are noticed less.

MORE EATING



Children end up eating more than they need.



Mindful eating begins when attention returns to the meal.



CHAPTER 9

SECTION 4

Mechanism 3 — Passive Sedentariness & Energy Balance

Screen time replaces movement, outdoor play, and physical exploration — all of which help regulate children's appetite and energy naturally.

1



LESS MOVEMENT

More screen time means less running, playing, building, and exploring.

2



APPETITE DYSREGULATION

Sedentary children often experience weaker hunger and fullness regulation.

3



STRONGER CRAVINGS

Low activity levels are linked to stronger cravings for highly processed, energy-dense foods.



MOVE MORE



Regular physical activity

BETTER APPETITE



Stronger hunger at meals

BETTER SATIETY



Improved fullness signals

HEALTHIER FOOD RESPONSE



More satisfied with nutritious foods



“Movement helps children regulate both energy and appetite naturally.”



Children's bodies are designed for movement, exploration, and active play.



CHAPTER 9

SECTION 5

Practical Strategies

Removing screens during meals improves mindfulness, portion awareness, family connection, and meal satisfaction.

1



SCREEN-FREE MEALTIMES

One screen-free family meal each day creates better eating awareness and connection.

2



BUILD MEDIA LITERACY

Help children understand how ads are designed to influence cravings and choices.

3



CREATE BETTER ALTERNATIVES

Use conversation, stories, or audiobooks instead of screens during meals and snacks.



“Children learn to eat mindfully when meals become moments of connection.”



ONE RULE, BIG IMPACT ♥

If you implement only one change from this entire book, consider making it this: **no screens during any meal or snack.** This single practice addresses food advertising exposure, mindless eating, portion dysregulation, and family connection in one move.



Chapter Reflection



“ The goal isn't less technology.
The goal is more mindful eating. ”

What This Chapter Was Really About



— .. ♥ .. —



1. Screens Change How Children Eat

When children eat while distracted, they notice food less and often eat beyond fullness.



2. Advertising Shapes Preferences

Food marketing influences cravings, requests, and brand recognition long before children understand advertising.



3. Family Connection Matters

Screen-free meals create space for conversation, awareness, and healthier food habits.

PAUSE & REFLECT

Which meal or snack time could become screen-free in your home this week?

.....

.....

.....





“ The goal isn't less technology.
The goal is more mindful eating. ”

Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to support screen-smart, mindful eating habits.



1. Set Screen-Free Meal Times.

Create daily routines where meals and snacks happen without screens, even if it's just one time a day.



2. Be Mindful of Advertising.

Limit exposure to ads and avoid food marketing during TV, YouTube, or online time.



3. Set Clear Screen Boundaries.

Agree on screen times and places so that eating happens with presence, not distraction.



4. Encourage Real Conversations.

Ask simple questions, listen to their day, and make mealtime a time to connect, not rush.



5. Model the Change.

Put your phone away too. Children copy what they see more than what they hear.



PAUSE & REFLECT

What is one screen habit your family could change to make mealtimes more connected this week?



CHAPTER 10

The Long Game — Raising an Adult With a Healthy Relationship With Food

Zooming out from daily battles to the bigger picture
of food freedom, balance, and lifelong habits.



CHAPTER 10

SECTION 1

The Person You Are Raising

Parenting around food is not about winning daily battles. It is about shaping a lifelong relationship with eating, body trust, and nourishment.

1



THINK LONG-TERM

You are not only feeding a child today — you are shaping the adult they become.

2



FOOD WITHOUT SHAME

The goal is an adult who eats with balance, enjoyment, and self-trust.

3



ORDINARY MOMENTS MATTER

A healthy relationship with food is built slowly across thousands of ordinary meals.

“The relationship your child develops with food matters more than any single meal.”



Children remember the emotional atmosphere around food long after they forget what was on the plate.



What the Research Says About Long-Term Outcomes

Research consistently shows that healthy adult eating patterns are shaped more by emotional atmosphere, modeling, and connection than by perfection or restriction.

THE RESEARCH IS CLEAR:



1. Regular family meals throughout childhood and adolescence



2. A home food environment with consistent availability of nutritious food



3. Parents who modelled enjoyment of a wide variety of foods



4. An absence of chronic restriction, food rules, and moralistic food language



5. Positive emotional associations with eating — connection, pleasure, culture, and celebration



6. Media literacy and critical thinking around food advertising

“The strongest predictor of healthy eating is not perfection — it is relationship.”



NOTICE WHAT THIS LIST DOES NOT INCLUDE:

- ✗ Perfect nutritional compliance at every meal
- ✗ Zero consumption of junk food
- ✗ Rigid adherence to any specific dietary philosophy
- ✗ A childhood free from birthday cake and festival sweets



The data is clear: the foundation of lifelong healthy eating is **emotional, environmental, and relational** — not disciplinary.



Children build lifelong food habits through connection, consistency, and emotional safety.



CHAPTER 10

SECTION 3

The Habits That Last

Habits formed in childhood persist into adulthood with remarkable tenacity. The food habits most likely to endure are not the ones that were enforced most strictly — they are the ones that were woven most naturally into the fabric of daily life.

1



The Family Meal Habit

Regular family meals lead to healthier eating as adults and lower risks of obesity, disordered eating, and disease. Make the family meal a daily ritual.

2



The Cooking Habit

Kids who learn to cook become adults who cook — and eat better. Home-cooked meals are more varied, less processed, and more satisfying. Teach them early.

3



The Vegetable Familiarity Habit

The vegetables kids eat today are the ones they'll choose tomorrow. Sustained, low-pressure exposure builds a palate that lasts a lifetime.



Small habits. Big impact.

- ✓ Sit together often.
- ✓ Cook simple meals together.
- ✓ Offer variety, without pressure.
- ✓ Keep trying with vegetables.
- ✓ Make food a part of connection, not conflict.

These little habits today become your child's normal tomorrow.

“ The habits we build around food today become the choices our children make automatically tomorrow. ”



Lifelong healthy eating isn't about perfection. It's about the habits that become home.

CHAPTER 10

SECTION 4

Releasing Perfectionism

Healthy eating is not built through perfection. It is built through consistency, trust, and emotional safety over time.

1 Difficult Days Are Normal

Every family goes through phases of fast food, picky eating, and survival meals.

2 Calm Matters More Than Control

A peaceful food environment supports healthier habits than constant battles.

3 The Foundation Still Holds

One difficult week does not erase years of connection and positive exposure.



“ You do not need to parent food perfectly to raise a healthy eater. ”



Children thrive most in food environments built on trust, flexibility, and connection.



CHAPTER 10

SECTION 5

Your Final Checklist — The 10 Things That Matter Most

These are the habits that matter most over the long run — not perfection, but consistency, connection, and trust.

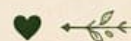
-  Eat together as a family as often as you practically can.
-  Stock your home consistently with a variety of nutritious foods.
-  Model enjoying vegetables and whole foods with visible pleasure.
-  Remove screens from mealtimes.
-  Use neutral, functional food language — no 'good foods' and 'bad foods'.
-  Keep family food culture positive, curious, and low-pressure.
-  Cook with your child at least once a week.
-  Allow all foods in appropriate contexts — no permanent forbidden foods.
-  Trust your child's hunger and fullness cues.
-  Take the long view — you are building a relationship, not winning a battle.



“ You are building a lifelong relationship with food — one ordinary meal at a time.



Connection around food
matters more than perfection around food.



Chapter Reflection

The Goal
Is
Independence.



“Success is not raising a child who obeys food rules. Success is raising an adult who trusts themselves around food.”

What This Chapter Was Really About



1. Healthy Eating Is a Life Skill

The goal isn't getting children to eat perfectly today.

The goal is helping them make good decisions when you're not there.



2. Trust Outlasts Control

Children develop healthier habits when food is guided with trust rather than pressure.



3. Relationship Matters More Than Rules

A positive relationship with food protects children long after childhood ends.



PAUSE & REFLECT

When your child becomes an adult, what food habit or mindset do you hope they carry with them?





“The goal is not raising a child who follows food rules. The goal is raising an adult who trusts themselves around food.”

Small Steps. Big Impact.

Simple actions you can take this week to help your child build a lifelong healthy relationship with food.



1. Teach One Food Skill

Show your child how to:

- wash fruit
- make a sandwich
- prepare a simple snack
- help with cooking

Small skills create lifelong confidence.



2. Let Them Make Choices

Offer options:

- “Would you like apple or banana?”
- “Rice or roti?”

Ownership builds responsibility.



3. Focus On Habits, Not Perfection

One meal never defines health.

Help children see food as a long-term pattern.



4. Model Balanced Eating

Let your child see you enjoy:

- vegetables
- family meals
- treats in moderation

Children learn more from what we do than what we say.



5. Think Beyond Childhood

Ask yourself: “Will this approach help my child when I’m not there?”

Use that question as your parenting compass.



PAUSE & REFLECT

What food skill, habit, or mindset would you most like your child to carry into adulthood?



11

BONUS SECTION

Real-Life Challenges Modern Parents Face

Parenting in today's world isn't easy. No matter how much we plan, real life brings unique challenges.



This bonus section gives you practical guidance, real solutions and quick answers to the questions parents ask every day.



1. GRANDPARENTS & FAMILY PRESSURE

Handle family food dynamics, set boundaries and stay consistent without conflict.



2. SCREEN TIME & FOOD ADDICTION

Break the snack-and-screen cycle and reduce the cravings loop caused by screens.



3. "MY CHILD REFUSED EVERYTHING FOR MONTHS"

Understand long food resistance phases and what actually helps. You're not alone.



4. WHEN LIFE GETS CHAOTIC

Healthy eating strategies for busy days, travel, illness, food emergencies and everything in between.



5. FAQ SECTION

Quick answers to the most common questions parents ask every day.

Small Steps
Strong Habits
Healthy Kids
Happy Future



1. GRANDPARENTS

*Deeper Guidance for
Multi-Generational Homes*



Grandparents are often one of the greatest emotional gifts in a child's life.

Their food, stories, routines, and affection become part of childhood memory itself.



But in modern food environments, multi-generational caregiving can also create tension — especially when parents and grandparents approach food very differently.



WHEN GRANDPARENTS ARE PRIMARY CAREGIVERS

The Real Dynamic

When a grandparent feeds your child 5 days a week, you cannot simply “choose your battles” — **you need a working alliance.**



The goal shifts from protecting individual meals to building a **shared food culture** across generations.



WHAT ACTUALLY WORKS

1

INVOLVE THEM IN THE GOAL



*“Dadi, we want him to
grow up loving your
home food.”*



2

CREATE A SHARED “YES” LIST



Roasted chana



Fruit



Curd with banana



Homemade snacks
(like mathri, thepla)

3

KEEP THE HANDOVER SIMPLE



Snack timing
(not within 90 minutes
of meals)



One treat maximum
per day



Water over juice
as the default drink



Correcting grandparents in front of the child usually creates defensiveness.

Protect the relationship first.



1. GRANDPARENTS

Deeper Guidance for
Multi-Generational Homes

NAVIGATING REAL-LIFE Family Situations



1 SCRIPTS FOR COMMON SITUATIONS

SITUATION	BETTER RESPONSE
 Dadi gives sweets before dinner	 "Can we keep the mithai for after dinner?"
 Forced feeding ("ek aur bite lo")	 "Can we let him stop when he feels full?"
 "You're being too strict"	 "I just want him to enjoy healthy food long-term."
 Different rules at grandparents' home	 Focus on your home baseline being strong.

"The goal is not to win arguments. The goal is to build a partnership that helps your child grow up healthy and happy — with love from everyone."



2 THE GENERATIONAL NUTRITION GAP

The environment has changed more than the parenting.

THEN (Our childhood)



- Home-cooked food
- Limited packaged snacks
- Less marketing
- More outdoor play

NOW (Their world today)



- Ultra-processed options everywhere
- 24x7 food availability
- Constant marketing to kids
- Less physical activity

Acknowledge the changes. Align with love. Move forward together.

3 CHOOSE THE BIG BATTLES



Daily patterns matter more than occasional sweets.



Consistent family meals matter more than perfect snacks.



Emotional safety at mealtimes matters more than perfection.

Progress, not perfection. That's the real win.

4 WHEN GRANDPARENTS USE FOOD AS LOVE



-  Older generations often experienced scarcity.
-  Feeding became love, care, and security.
-  Refusing food may feel like rejecting affection.

See the love behind the food. Then guide with patience.

5 THE FESTIVAL EXCEPTION



Festival food creates memories too. Enjoy, celebrate, and return to routine calmly.

6 WHEN YOUR PARTNER DISAGREES WITH YOU



One parent being stricter creates mixed messages. Agree on 2-3 shared non-negotiables. Present a united front with love and respect.



Love + Consistency + Patience = Healthy Habits for Life

2. SCREEN TIME

*Stronger Solutions
for Modern Families*



THE PROBLEM RESTATED SIMPLY

Every minute of screen time does **three** things simultaneously: exposes your child to food advertising, reduces their awareness of hunger and fullness, and replaces physical activity that would naturally regulate appetite.

*It's not one problem —
it's three happening at once.*



EVERY MINUTE OF SCREEN TIME DOES THREE THINGS AT ONCE



1 FOOD ADVERTISING

Constant ads make unhealthy foods look normal, fun and desirable.



2 MINDLESS EATING

Screens distract the brain, so children eat more and don't notice when they're full.



3 LESS MOVEMENT

Less movement means lower energy needs and poorer appetite regulation.



CONNECTED. MINDFUL. NO SCREENS.



- ✓ Better appetite awareness
- ✓ Family conversation
- ✓ Balanced eating
- ✓ Stronger habits



DISTRACTED. MINDLESS. MORE SNACKS.



- ✗ More ad exposure
- ✗ Poor hunger signals
- ✗ Overeating
- ✗ Fewer family moments



DON'T PANIC. YOU CAN CHANGE THIS. ♥

If your child already loves screens and snacks, you have not "ruined" their eating habits. These associations are learned gradually — and can be changed gradually too.



PRACTICAL SOLUTIONS BY AGE



AGES 2-5: ENVIRONMENT SOLVES IT



No screens during any eating occasion, full stop.



Screens in common areas only, never bedrooms.



Create a "screen corner" that is physically separate from the kitchen and dining area.



Replace pre-meal screen time with a 10-minute outdoor or physical activity buffer — this naturally reduces the screen-to-snack association.



Environment shapes behaviour more powerfully than willpower at this age.



AGES 6-9: MEDIA LITERACY BEGINS

Children this age can start understanding that ads are designed to make them want things.

"Did you notice how that burger looked? In real life it's much smaller and less shiny. Companies spend a lot of money making food look better than it is on screen. Cool trick, right? Kind of sneaky though."



AD DETECTIVE GAME

When a food ad plays, ask:
"What are they trying to make you feel? Happy? Cool? Left out?"

Children who learn to identify the emotion being targeted become significantly more resistant to it.



AGES 10-12: FULL TRANSPARENCY



Food companies spend more money marketing to children than to adults because children influence family purchasing.



Their favourite YouTubers are often paid to eat certain foods on camera.



"Unboxing snack" videos are advertisements.

This doesn't make children cynical — it makes them discerning.



REMEMBER:

You're not trying to eliminate screens.
You're raising a thinker in a digital world.



Curiosity, conversation and consistency today build resilience for tomorrow.



THE ONE RULE THAT CHANGES EVERYTHING

NO SCREENS DURING ANY MEAL OR SNACK.

Not sometimes. Not on difficult days. Every time.



Reduces food advertising exposure



Restores hunger and fullness awareness



Creates space for family conversation



Supports more movement and healthier habits



IMPLEMENTATION TIP:

Don't announce it as a new rule.
Simply stop having screens at mealtimes.
When asked, say "we're eating now, screens after."
Most children adapt within 2 weeks.

MANAGING THE SNACK-SCREEN ASSOCIATION

Break the habit gradually, not abruptly.



WEEKS 1-2

Screens still happen, but snacks are served before screens begin, at the table, finished before the screen turns on.



WEEKS 3-4

Snacks move entirely to the kitchen, finished before moving to the screen area.



WEEKS 5+

The physical separation between eating space and screen space becomes the norm.



DON'T PANIC. YOU CAN CHANGE THIS.

If your child already loves screens and snacks, you have not "ruined" their eating habits.

These associations are learned gradually — and can be changed gradually too.



You're not trying to eliminate screens.
You're raising a thinker in a digital world.



Curiosity, conversation and consistency today build resilience for tomorrow.



DON'T FORGET:

You are not just managing screens.
You are shaping your child's future relationship with food, body and self.



Small changes today



Consistent habits



Stronger connections



Healthier kids tomorrow

3. WHEN CHILDREN RESIST FOR MONTHS



1 FIRST: UNDERSTAND WHAT NORMAL LOOKS LIKE

Research in feeding therapy is unambiguous on one point: the timeline parents expect is 10 times shorter than the timeline that actually works.

PARENTS EXPECT



Offer new food
3–4 times →
child accepts it.

REALITY



10–15 neutral exposures
before acceptance
even begins.

20–30 exposures for
children with strong
neophobia.

If your child has been refusing broccoli for three months, you may be at exposure 8 of 15.



*You are not failing.
You are in the middle of a normal process
that has no visible progress markers.*

2 THE RESISTANCE PLATEAU

Around weeks 6–10 of a new food approach, many families hit a resistance plateau.

The novelty of the new approach has worn off. Old patterns reassert. Parents interpret this as evidence the approach isn't working — when they are actually closest to a breakthrough.

SIGNS YOU'RE IN A RESISTANCE PLATEAU, NOT A GENUINE FAILURE:

- ✓ Your child was showing small signs of progress before the regression
- ✓ The resistance is louder than it was initially (this often means change is occurring)
- ✓ You have maintained a calm, low-pressure environment throughout
- ✓ The regression coincided with an external stressor: illness, school transition, family disruption

3 WHAT TO DO DURING A RESISTANCE PLATEAU

1 REDUCE, DON'T ELIMINATE



Continue offering the food but reduce frequency and completely remove any pressure, comment, or emotional investment.

**The food appears. Nothing is said.
You eat it with visible enjoyment.
End of interaction.**

2 BROADEN BEFORE DEEPENING



If your child is stuck on three vegetables, temporarily stop pushing those three and introduce variety elsewhere.

A child who accepts 20 different foods — even if none of them are broccoli — is in a far stronger nutritional position than a child who has been pressured into eating broccoli and now has stress responses to mealtimes.

3 DOCUMENT TINY PROGRESS



Parents who are struggling often cannot see progress because they are measuring against the wrong outcome.

Keep a simple note on your phone.
Not "did they eat it" but "did they touch it / smell it / lick it / putt it in their mouth and spit it out." Each of these is a genuine step in the feeding therapy progression.



Progress in feeding is often invisible before it becomes obvious.



3. WHEN CHILDREN RESIST FOR MONTHS

REALISTIC EXPECTATIONS TAKE PRESSURE OFF PARENTS

1 MONTH-BY-MONTH REALISTIC EXPECTATIONS

MONTH 1	MONTH 2	MONTH 3	MONTH 4-5	MONTH 6+
				
				
Child notices new foods are appearing. Mostly ignores them.	Child interacts with new food without eating — pushes it around the plate, asks questions, watches you eat.	First taste attempt, possibly with dramatic negative reaction. <i>This is progress, not failure.</i>	Inconsistent tasting. Accepts on some days, refuses on others. This variability is normal and temporary.	Gradual normalisation. The food becomes part of the landscape. Acceptance gradually follows.

If you are in month 2 expecting month 6 results, you will feel like you are failing when you are actually on track.

2 WHEN TO SEEK PROFESSIONAL HELP

The strategies in this book work for typical picky eating and food preference development. They are not designed for:



Children who gag or vomit
at the sight, smell, or proximity of certain foods



Children who eat
fewer than 15–20 different foods total



Children whose food restriction
is causing significant weight, growth, or nutritional concerns



Children whose anxiety around food
is affecting their ability to attend school events, social occasions, or family meals



Children who have been diagnosed with
or show signs of autism, sensory processing disorder, or ARFID



If any of these describe your child, a paediatric dietitian or feeding therapist is the appropriate next step.

Seeking professional support is not a parenting failure — it is the most effective thing you can do.

3 FINAL REASSURANCE

Seeking professional help is not a parenting failure.

It is often the most supportive and effective next step for your child.



You are doing your best with the knowledge you have today.



Small, consistent actions over time create lasting change.



You don't have to do this alone. Support makes a difference.



Every calm meal is building your child's future relationship with food.



Consistency matters more than speed.



4. WHEN LIFE GETS CHAOTIC



1 THE BASELINE PRINCIPLE

Healthy eating is not built only during normal life. It is built during normal life, sustained through chaotic life, and recovered quickly after disrupted life.



The goal is not a perfect system that works when everything is calm.

The goal is a **resilient baseline that bends without breaking** when life goes sideways.



2 THE RECOVERY MEAL

Every chaotic eating period — festival season, illness, travel, a week of takeaways — ends the same way:

one normal home-cooked meal, served without comment about what came before.



No "health kick" announcements.



No compensatory salads.



Just dal, sabzi, roti, and moving forward.



Children slot back into normal eating patterns remarkably quickly when there is no drama around the transition.



A resilient food culture matters more than a perfect food routine.



THE CHAOS TOOLKIT

1 THE 3-FOOD RULE

On genuinely difficult days, aim for three things only:



One source of protein



One fruit or vegetable in any form



Adequate water



That's it.

No balance, no variety, no guilt.



Dal chawal with a banana on the side is a complete difficult-day meal.

3 THE EMERGENCY PANTRY

Keep these available at all times for genuinely difficult days when cooking is not possible:



Whole grain bread or rotis (frozen)



Peanut butter or any nut butter



Canned or tetrapak dal/rajma



Seasonal fruit that needs no preparation



Eggs



Curd



Roasted chana or mixed nuts



With these seven items you can construct a nutritionally adequate meal in under five minutes, on the hardest day of the year.



Even when everything else slides, protect these two things.

4. WHEN LIFE GETS CHAOTIC

1 NO SCREENS DURING MEALS

(This is easier to maintain than any food rule and has the highest payoff.)

2 EAT TOGETHER AT THE TABLE AT LEAST ONCE PER DAY,

even if the food is simple or imperfect.



These two anchors maintain the food relationship even when the food itself is temporarily imperfect.



+ ILLNESS SPECIFICALLY

Children eat dramatically less during and immediately after illness. This is normal, universal, and temporary. Parental anxiety can create pressure, which creates new problems.



DURING ILLNESS



Offer small portions



Offer familiar, liked foods



Offer extra fluids



AVOID



Pressure feeding



Food lectures



Introducing new foods

REASSURANCE



Appetite typically normalises within **5-10 days** after recovery.

Trust the process.

“Children recover from imperfect weeks far faster than parents recover from food guilt.”



Progress over perfection



Consistency over control



Connection over pressure

5. FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS



1 My child ate everything until age 2. What happened?



Picky eating typically begins between 18 months–3 years.



This is biological, not bad parenting.



Repeated calm exposure matters most.



*You did not create this.
You are navigating a normal developmental phase.*



2 Why do they eat better at school but refuse the same food at home?



Social eating normalises foods.



Peers reduce resistance.



Pressure at home can increase refusal.

WHAT HELPS AT HOME:



Family meals together



Less negotiation



Less emotional pressure

3 Should I hide vegetables in food?

VISIBLE VEGETABLES



VS.

HIDDEN VEGETABLES



Okay as a short-term nutritional bridge.



Not a permanent strategy.



*Pair hidden vegetables with visible ones.
Exposure to real vegetables must continue.*

4 My child eats only 5 foods. Should I be worried?



Track the number of foods monthly, not daily.



Temporary phases are common.



Severe, long-term restriction may need professional assessment.



Look at the trajectory, not just today's plate.

5 Is it okay to use dessert as a reward for eating dinner?



Using dessert as a reward increases children's preference for dessert and decreases their preference for the food they had to eat.



Serve dessert as a normal, unconditional part of the meal — a small portion alongside dinner, not after it.



Vegetables should not feel like punishment.



Most feeding struggles improve when pressure reduces.



5. FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS



6 My child asks for junk food by name and by brand. They're only 3. How?



Children recognise 100+ brand logos before they can read.



Billions are spent marketing to children under 5.



Reduce food advertising exposure (screens).



Build a strong home food environment.



Use the "sometimes foods" framework consistently.

7 We eat out 3–4 times a week. Is that too much?



Frequency matters less than:



What you order



How you eat



Whether screens are involved



Mindful restaurant meals are different from rushed screen meals.

8 My husband/partner undermines everything I'm trying to do at mealtimes. How do I handle this?



Discuss outside the kitchen, outside mealtimes, and outside conflict.



Agree on 2–3 specific practices, not a full philosophy overhaul.



Prioritise calm tone over perfect consistency.



Children notice divided mealtime environments quickly.

9 What about milk? My child drinks a lot of milk and I'm not sure if that's replacing food.



Excess milk can reduce appetite for solid foods.



Offer milk after meals, not before.



Limit to 2 cups per day for toddlers.



Full-fat milk under 2; reduced fat from age 2 onwards.

10 My child eats well at home but goes to birthday parties and completely loses control — eating everything in sight. Is this normal?



This is scarcity-based eating — the brain thinks treats are rare and eats as much as possible when available.



It develops when treats are restricted or moralised at home.

The Better Long-Term Approach



Make treats slightly less rare and less emotionally charged.



Offer small sweets with dinner occasionally (e.g., twice a week).



Use the "sometimes foods" framework.



Consistent, calm, no drama.



A child who occasionally gets sweets at home feels less urgency around them elsewhere.



You are not trying to raise a perfectly controlled eater.
You are raising a child who can eventually self-regulate around food.





Final Reflection



What This Book Was Really About

1

Healthy Eating Is Bigger Than Food

Food habits are shaped by relationships, environments, routines, and experiences.



2

Progress Beats Perfection

Small changes repeated consistently matter more than perfect days.



3

You Have More Influence Than You Think

Even in a world full of junk food marketing, parents still shape the environment that matters most.

*“ Your child doesn’t need a perfect parent.
They need a present one. ”*



What is the single most important idea you are taking away from this book?





Our Family Action Plan



Small Steps. Big Impact.

Choose one area your family would like to focus on over the next month.

☐

Improve Our Home Food Environment

Make healthier foods easier to see, reach, and enjoy.

☐

Reduce Mealtime Pressure

Focus on calm meals, not clean plates.

☐

Build More Food Curiosity

Encourage touching, smelling, helping, and exploring food.

☐

Create More Screen-Free Meals

Protect family connection during mealtimes.

☐

Improve Our Snack Habits

Make nutritious snacks the easy choice.

☐

Focus On Progress, Not Perfection

Celebrate small wins and keep moving forward.

“ A healthy food culture is built one small decision at a time. ”

♥
This Month We Will Focus On:

♥
Success Will Look Like:





Thank You



Thank you for spending your time with this book.

Parenting is filled with uncertainty,
especially when it comes to food.

If there is one message I hope you carry with you,
it is this:

Healthy eating is not built through pressure,
perfection, or control.

It is built through connection, consistency,
curiosity, and countless small moments that
often go unnoticed.

Every fruit offered.
Every family meal shared.
Every calm conversation.
Every opportunity to explore something new.

These moments matter.
More than you think.



“ Small changes
create lifelong habits. ”



Here's to raising confident eaters,
curious learners, and healthy adults.



With gratitude,



BEFORE WE TALK ABOUT JUNK FOOD... WE NEED TO TALK ABOUT HOME.

Long before children face birthday parties, advertisements, school canteens and supermarket temptations, they build their **first relationship with food at home.**

THE DAILY FOOD BATTLE

Pressure. Negotiation. Frustration.



Just one bite.



Bribing with treats.



Constant negotiations.



Stress for everyone.

THE FOUNDATION WE WANT

Connection. Curiosity. Confidence.



They explore new foods.



They enjoy healthy food.



They make choices with confidence.



Peace at the table.



THE GOAL WAS NEVER TO
MAKE CHILDREN EAT VEGETABLES.
THE GOAL WAS TO HELP THEM WANT TO.

Children who enjoy healthy foods don't need constant convincing.

They carry those choices with them into



School



Parties



Restaurants



Holidays



Real life

THAT'S THE FOUNDATION BEHIND EAT YOUR GREEN GUIDE.

A practical approach to helping children build **confidence, curiosity and connection** with healthy foods—without pressure, bribery or food battles.



- ✓ Help children enjoy a wide range of healthy foods.
- ✓ Build positive eating habits that last a lifetime.
- ✓ Make mealtimes joyful, not stressful.
- ✓ Raise confident eaters, not reluctant ones.



TURN THE PAGE TO DISCOVER ANOTHER CHALLENGE
MODERN FAMILIES FACE:

SCREENS, DEVICES AND
THE DIGITAL WORLD.



Not Every Struggle Is About Food



You've worked hard to improve your child's eating habits—one meal, one choice at a time.

But many parents discover that once food battles improve, a new challenge often takes their place.



Screen-time requests.



Arguments about devices.



Difficulty switching off.



Constant entertainment seeking.



Today's children are growing up in a digital world, and many families are searching for a healthier balance.



THE CHALLENGE HAS CHANGED



FOOD BATTLES

Working on healthier eating and better habits.



SCREEN STRUGGLES

New daily battles around screens and devices.



HEALTHIER DIGITAL HABITS

Stronger balance, calmer homes, deeper connections.



What if there was a simple way to better understand what may be driving screen-time struggles **before reacting**?



Introducing a powerful idea from *Raising Healthy Kids in a Digital World*

On the next pages, you'll discover a simple yet effective framework that can help you respond with more understanding, create healthier screen habits, and build stronger connections with your child.



Turn the Page →

Discover a simple framework that helps parents approach screen-time battles with greater understanding and confidence.



MEET THE **HALT** FRAMEWORK™

—♥ A simple tool to understand what your child may need ♥—
before reacting to screen-time struggles.

H

HUNGRY

My child might be hungry and need food or a healthy snack.

Signs your child might show:

- Complains or seems irritable
- Low energy
- Asks for screens instead of food



A

ANGRY

Big feelings like frustration or anger may be driving their behaviour.

Signs your child might show:

- Easily annoyed
- Argues or refuses suddenly
- Explosive or meltdown behavior



L

LONELY

They might be seeking connection, attention or a sense of belonging.

Signs your child might show:

- Wants company
- Follows you around
- Uses screens to fill boredom or feel included



T

TIRED

Overtired children struggle to cope and screens become an easy escape.

Signs your child might show:

- Whiny or cranky
- Trouble focusing
- Resists stopping screens



**Connection first.
Screens second.**

When we understand the need behind the behaviour, we can respond with empathy, build trust and create healthier screen habits together.



HALT IN REAL LIFE

Two common moments. One simple approach.

1 AFTER-SCHOOL SCREEN REQUEST



Can I watch YouTube?

Parent thinks:

HALT = HUNGRY?

What's really going on?
His body needs fuel.

Response:

"Let's have a snack first and then decide."



HALT Check:

He was hungry, **not avoiding** homework.

2 BEFORE BED – "ONE MORE VIDEO!"



Parent thinks:

HALT = TIRED?

What's really going on?
His body needs rest, not more stimulation.

Response:

"Looks like your body needs sleep more than another video."



HALT Check:

He was **tired**, not being stubborn.

A SIMPLE PAUSE CAN CHANGE EVERYTHING



PAUSE

Take a breath before you react.



CHECK HALT

What might my child need?



CONNECT

Meet the need with love and understanding.



DECIDE

Choose screen time with clarity.



Small pauses.
Better choices.
Stronger connections.



Understanding comes before limits. Because connection changes everything. ♥

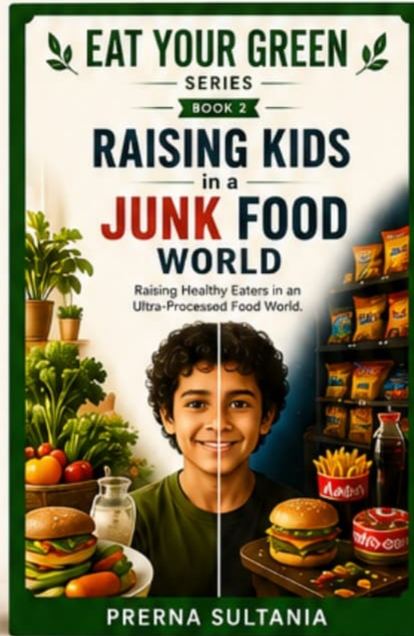
CONTINUE YOUR HEALTHY CHILDHOOD *Journey* ♥

Supporting healthier habits, stronger connections
and happier childhoods—one step at a time.



1 EAT YOUR GREEN GUIDE

Transform mealtime battles into positive food experiences and help your child build a lifelong relationship with healthy eating.



2 RAISING KIDS IN A JUNK FOOD WORLD

Navigate ultra-processed foods, marketing influences and everyday temptations with practical strategies that support healthier choices.



3 RAISING HEALTHY KIDS IN A DIGITAL WORLD

Use the 4B Framework™ to create healthier screen habits, stronger family connections and a better balance between screens and real life.



Join Our PARENT COMMUNITY

Practical parenting tips, encouragement, challenges and support for raising healthier, happier children.



Explore More RESOURCES

Discover bonus resources, printable tools, parenting guides and updates from the Eat Your Green Series.



eatyourgreen.co.in



Prerna Sultania

Author • Creator
Healthy Kids Educator

“ Every healthy childhood is built one small choice, one meaningful moment and one loving connection at a time. ”